

DESCEND FROM 30

Art Brief for contracting pixel artists

A 2D side-scrolling pixel-art roguelike (Godot 4.6). Survivors descend a 30-floor apartment building during a zombie outbreak — scavenging apartments and fighting through corridors, floor by floor, to the lobby. One playthrough is three characters (a morning, an afternoon and a night run) through the same building as it decays. Everything plays on a single flat walking plane; the camera scrolls left/right.

Tone — “cozy horror”

Warm, lived-in apartments turned quietly dangerous. Dread comes from atmosphere, light and decay — not gore-splatter. Grounded, slightly muted palette; strong, readable silhouettes. The title art below is the mood target.

Scope at a glance

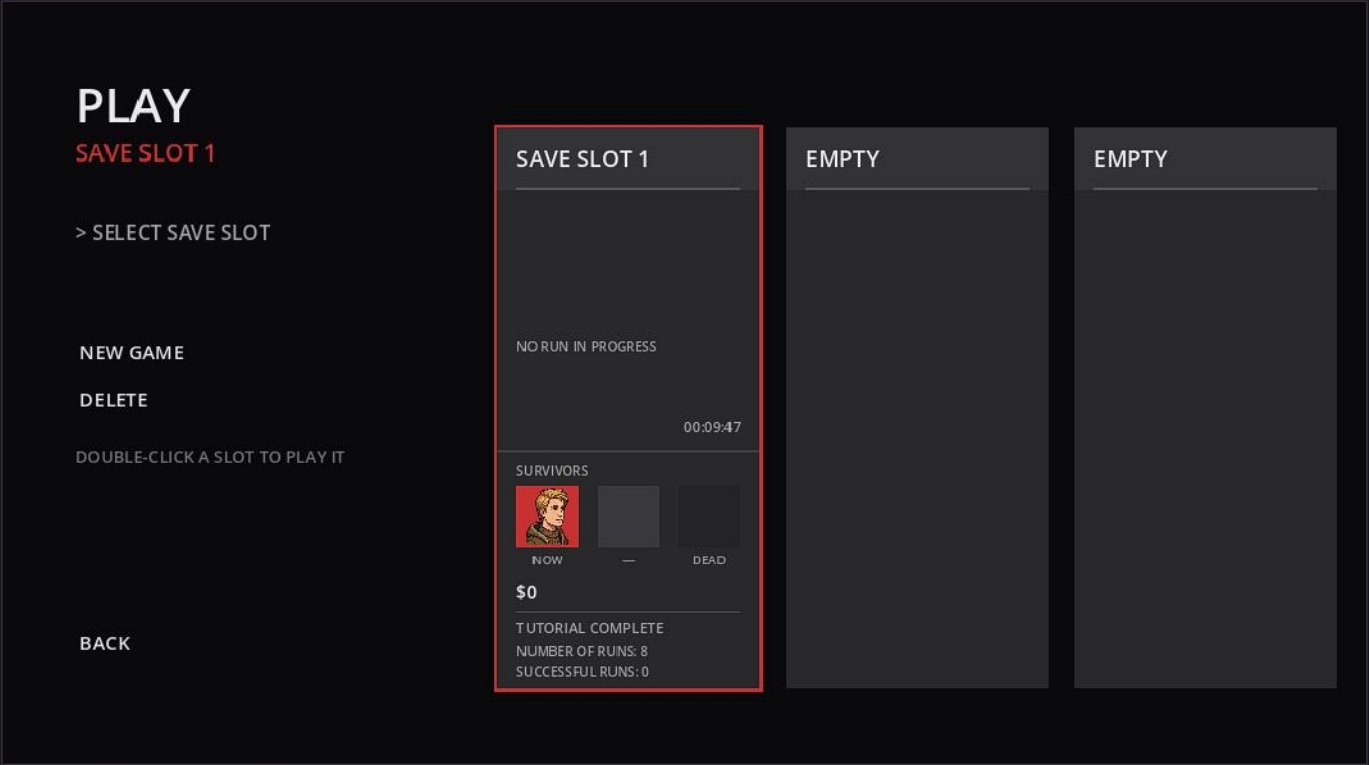
This is a full game art package, not a one-off: player character sprites (multiple survivors), enemy sprites, NPCs, inventory + in-world items, environments (varied corridors, modular rooms, stairwells, elevator, lobby), UI / HUD, and player health-state portraits. Sections below break each down.



Title screen — the tone/mood we are aiming for.

Where it is today

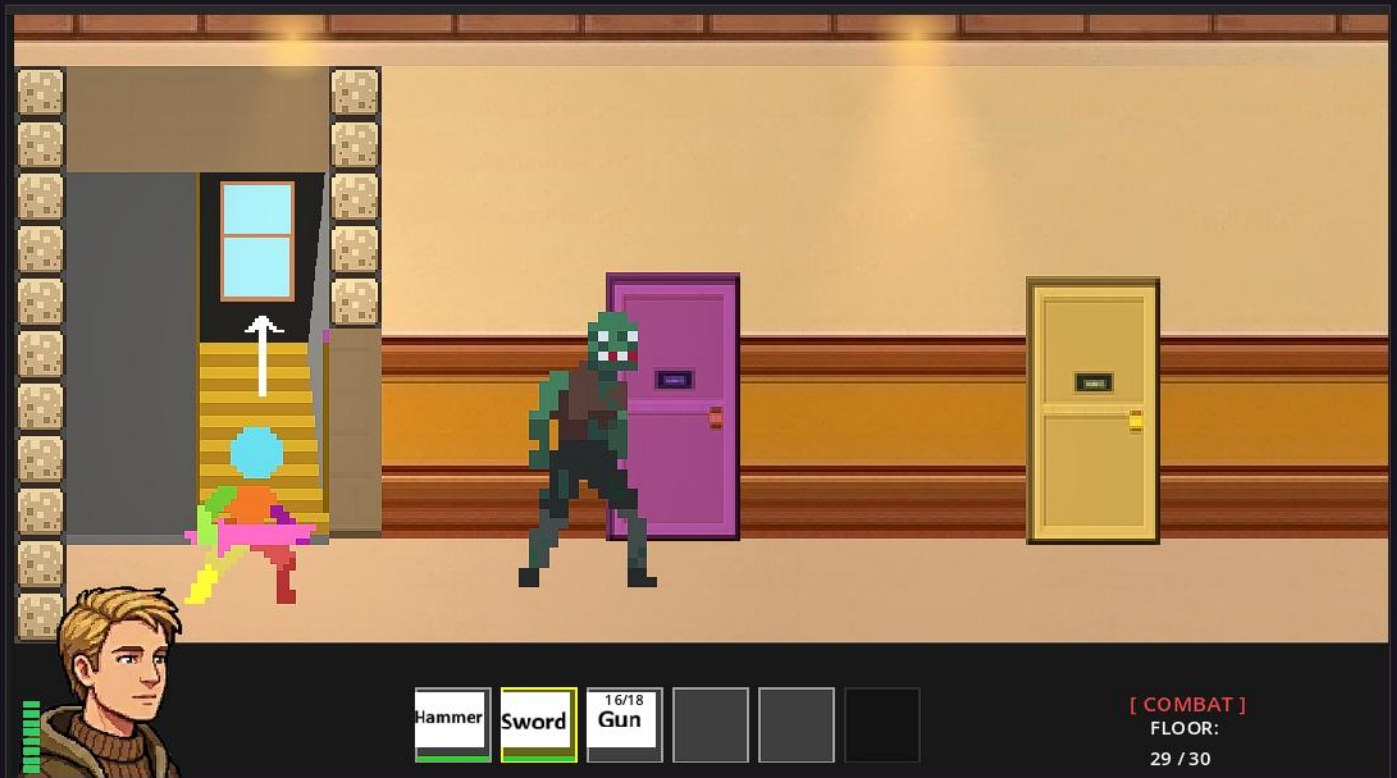
Current build with placeholder art — what you'd be replacing/adding to.



Save-slot / Play menu — UI style + survivor portraits (three runs per save).



Controls / Settings — UI style, list rows, rebind buttons.





Merchant floor — the merchant trades from inside the elevator. Note the warm ceiling light cones (the engine's dynamic lighting), the wall-mounted fire extinguisher, and a corpse on the floor. The window sits at the stairwell (right).

Critical conventions (read first — these prevent re-work)

- **ONE FEET BASELINE.** Every character/enemy stands on the same floor line. Author each sheet so the character's FEET sit at a fixed row in the frame, identical across all frames and all characters; tell us that feet offset. (Our placeholder rigs were authored at different scales/paddings, so their drawn feet don't line up — the #1 thing to fix.)
- **AUTHOR ART FLAT / NEUTRALLY LIT** — the engine does the lighting. The game adds REAL dynamic 2D lighting on top (warm lamp pools, fire glow, cool moonlight, darkness). So NO baked hard highlights or cast shadows on characters/props (a soft contact-shadow under the feet is welcome). Every asset must still read when the only light on it is a single warm pool in a near-black room (night).
- **AUTHOR FACING RIGHT** — the engine mirrors for left. Avoid asymmetric details that break when flipped.
- **Transparent background, no baked scenery in a character sheet.** Pixel-perfect: integer frames, crisp edges, nearest-neighbour safe.

Scale & density

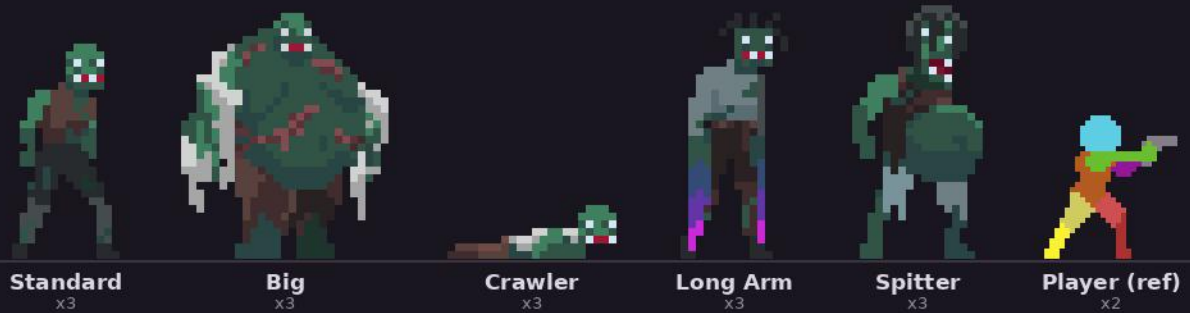
- Game renders 1152x648, chunky pixels. Standard humanoids read ~90-110 px tall on screen; author at a tight native frame (~64° for a human, larger for the Big) and we scale in-engine — deliver native px + the intended scale factor.
- Bigger creatures are TALLER, not lower — feet still on the same floor line.
- **CONSISTENT CHARACTER HEIGHT** (important — a live gameplay issue): today's PLACEHOLDER player reads only ~56 px tall while the zombies are ~84-99 px, so the player is the odd one out — tall enemies (Long Arm, Spitter) tower and their attacks read as passing over the player's head. New art must fix this: the player and a standard zombie should stand at ROUGHLY the same height, with attack reach at a matching level; bigger types (Big) are taller but proportioned so their hits still land on the player. All feet on the shared baseline.

Characters & enemies

Placeholder rigs shown at true in-game scale, feet aligned.

Descend From 30 — Enemy line-up (placeholder rigs)

True in-game scale, feet aligned to the floor line. Player shown for scale.



Five enemies. They currently SHARE one rig (reskins) — we need DISTINCT silhouettes: the Standard zombie; the Big (a larger, heavier zombie with a heavy attack); the Crawler (low, dragging along the ground); the Long Arm (extended reach); and the Spitter (ranged, with a spit projectile). Each needs: idle, walk/move, attack, hit/stagger, death.

Descend From 30 — Player (placeholder rig)

Gun idle · sword idle · crouch · push. True in-game scale, feet aligned.



The four poses above are stills; the placeholder player rig ALSO already includes full attack animation sheets (melee swing + gun shoot) and the walk/run/crouch/hurt/death cycles — all available as reference for timing and frame counts.

- Player — full set: idle, walk, run, crouch-idle/walk, scavenge, melee attack, gun (idle/walk/run/shoot), hurt, death, door-approach + knock, balcony rope-lash + climb.
- Enemies — Standard, Big (larger, heavy attack), Crawler, Long Arm, Spitter.
- NPCs — the Merchant already exists in-game (trades from inside the elevator car); MORE NPCs will need designing later (e.g. a barricade-keeper survivor, and others as the story grows).

Player health stages

The character visibly deteriorates as they take damage.

Descend From 30 — Player health stages (HUD portrait)

Healthy → Dying. Shown bottom-left of the HUD; degrades as the character takes damage.



Six HUD portrait states, Healthy → Dying (shown bottom-left of the HUD). These are TEMPORARY and show ONE player character. We plan MULTIPLE playable characters — male and female body types, up to ~8 potential survivors — and EACH needs the same six health-state portraits (escalating injury, blood and exhaustion) plus its own full body sprite set. Match this progression per character.

Environment & modular rooms

- Corridor / hallway set: wall, baseboard/trim, ceiling, floor — with VARIETY. The player descends 30 floors; the corridor must NOT feel like the same background 30 times. We need several corridor variants (layout/decor/wear) AND day-state/immersion differences, so each stretch feels distinct as you go down (this is separate from the top→bottom decay below).
- Apartment doors BY STATE: closed, open, locked, weak/damaged, barricaded, breached.

- Stairwells (an up flight + a dark down shaft); windows (stairwell + apartment balcony — daylight/moonlight comes through these).
- Elevator (corridor doors + the interior car), maintenance room (workbench, fuse box), lobby, and the floor-30 hallway.
- MODULAR apartment rooms — bedroom, kitchen, bathroom, study, living room, dining room; each a self-contained ~320 px-wide module (three sit side by side per apartment), furnished for scavenging (see the Bathroom shot). Same anti-repetition rule: a FEW variations per room type, not the same bathroom every time.
- Props: crate-stack barricade, corpse, world-drop pickups, keys, wall fire-extinguisher.

Sectional identity — the descent DECAYS (a key pillar)

The infection is worst at the bottom, so the building should visibly rot the lower you go. Deliver corridor + door (ideally room-dressing) variants across three bands:

- Floors 30-21 (top): clean, intact, lived-in.
- Floors 20-11 (mid): disturbed — damage, blood, disorder, breaking down.
- Floors 10-1 + lobby (bottom): grotesque — heavy infection growth, corruption, ruin.

Time of day

The ENGINE lights and tints each run dynamically — author art once, neutrally lit.

- MORNING (run 1): bright daytime. Near-fully lit, minimal shadow — art reads at true colour, the dynamic lighting barely intrudes (see the Morning shot).
- AFTERNOON (run 2): a cooler dusk. Warm interior light pools begin to matter against a colder fill — the cozy-horror contrast starts here (see the Afternoon shot).
- NIGHT (run 3): NOT YET FINAL (in development — no shippable night scene to show). Target: near-black corridors lit ONLY by lamp pools, fire, moonlight through windows, and the player's faint aura. Enemies lurk unseen in the dark until you're on them (jump-scares). Deep dread; the building at its most hostile. We want art that survives this: readable in a single warm pool, sinister in shadow.

Because the engine handles the light, do NOT deliver separate day/night versions of an asset unless we ask — one neutral version is lit three ways.

Items & UI

We also need ITEM art — inventory icons and in-world pickups (weapons, tools, medical, food, junk, keys, cash, etc.), readable at small HUD size. There are ~36 items; a full per-item spec exists on our side and we'll share it when we get to this — for now, just flagging that item design is part of the scope.

And UI: the HUD (portrait frame, hotbar slots, floor/mode readouts) and menu screens (title, save-slots, settings) — see the shots on page 2 for the current placeholder style. A cohesive UI pass is part of the package.

Deliverables & naming

- PNG, transparent, nearest-filter-safe. Sprite sheets as horizontal strips (one animation per row) or per-file frames — be consistent and tell us the layout.
- Per animation: name, frame count, frame size, suggested fps, loop/one-shot, feet offset.
- Naming: subject_anim.png — e.g. player_walk.png, zombie_standard_attack.png, door_barricaded.png, corridor_wall_mid.png.
- FIRST: a palette swatch + one “hero” mock of a lit corridor with a character, so we can lock the look before full sets.